Research — Xbox Game Library UI

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Summary

The Xbox library to model is the Xbox PC app's "My Library": a left sidebar beside a tabbed library (My games, My apps, Play history) that since September 2025 aggregates installed games from Steam, Battle.net, Epic, GOG and other launchers, and since April 2026 accepts any .exe added by hand. That is the same job our app does, and its layout of sidebar, flat content, rounded cards and pill actions maps closely onto libadwaita's split view, header bar and card styles.

Two related surfaces inform the rest: the console's "My games & apps" (groups, poster tiles, badge toggles, rich sort list) and "Xbox mode", formerly the full screen experience, a controller-driven fullscreen shell that reached all Windows 11 PCs from 2026-04-30. A rebuild of the PC app (codename "Garrison") was previewed in October 2026 and has not shipped. Microsoft publishes few pixel-level specs, so tile geometry and exact filter and sort lists are only partly confirmed.

Microsoft's trademark guidelines forbid using its logos, designs or trade dress in another app: we copy the information architecture, not the brand.

Surfaces and versions

Three Microsoft surfaces have a game library today; the PC app is the main model, the console adds collection and tile ideas, and Xbox mode is the fullscreen reference.

Surface	Key dates	Library entry point	Library features
Xbox PC app (Windows 11)	Aggregated library to Insiders 2025-06-23, to everyone 2025-09-15; manual add in app 2604.1001.9.0 (2026-04-20); launch parameters in 2606.1001.27.0 (2026-06-09); "Garrison" rebuild previewed 2026-10-09	My Library in the left sidebar, plus a Most recent list	Tabs My games, My apps, Play history; filters for installed, owned, Game Pass, cloud playable, genre, players; per-store hide toggles; + manual add; pin up to 3 games; store-origin icon and handheld badges on tiles
Xbox console (Series X|S, One)	Library redesign September 2022; filters January 2024; Game Hubs March–April 2025; Play History tab and 10 Home groups April 2026; owned/shared filters June 2026; poster tiles and badge toggles July 2026	My games & apps from Home or the Guide	Left pane with Games, Apps, Full library, Groups, Manage, Play History; sort, filter and search above lists; poster or default tiles
Xbox mode (formerly full screen experience)	ROG Xbox Ally 2025-10-16; all handhelds 2025-11-21; renamed and rolling out to Windows 11 PCs 2026-04-30	Library in the left rail; Library button on the Ally and in Game Bar	Multi-select categories (for example Owned + Installable), large cards, My apps tab, task switcher, desktop toggle (Win+F11)

Library layout

All three surfaces pair a left navigation pane with a library that combines tabs, stackable filters and a sort control over large art tiles, with the store of origin shown as a badge.

Navigation

- PC app: left sidebar with My Library and a Most recent list (toggle between most recent and installed); play history is both in the sidebar and a tab; compact mode shrinks the sidebar to icons.
- Xbox mode: left rail with Home, Game Pass, Cloud Gaming, Library, Store, Social.
- Console: left pane with Games, Apps, Full library, Groups, Manage, Play History. Full library has source tabs (All games, Owned, Game Pass, EA Play); Play History is a horizontal layout grouped by recency; Manage holds storage and update settings.

Filters

Surface	Filters
PC app	Installed, owned, Game Pass, cloud playable, handheld compatible; players, rating, genre, "untouched"; access type (Game Pass, purchase, gift). Stores are hidden per launcher in Settings > Library & Extensions; an in-library launcher filter is unconfirmed
Xbox mode	Several categories at once, for example Owned + Installable to show games that run natively
Console	Console type, players, genre (18), accessibility options, supported languages, technical capabilities; owned vs shared; "Game access" shows installed titles you no longer own

Sort

- Console: A–Z, group by letter, group by console type, size, last used, last update; subscription tabs default to recently added.
- PC app: installed size and maturity rating added in 2023; no sort by date acquired; the full current list is unconfirmed.

Views and tiles

- No grid/list toggle was found on PC (likely absent). The console offers tile size and, since July 2026, a "rich poster-style" tile style.

- Store art specs (Microsoft Learn): 2:3 poster (720×1080 or 1440×2160) is the main image, with title kept in the top two-thirds because overlays may cover the bottom third; 1:1 box art (1080×1080) as fallback; 16:9 super hero art (1920×1080) with no text and a possible gradient on the bottom third.
- Console default tiles appear square, with 2:3 posters optional (inferred). Xbox mode uses large cards (ratio unconfirmed).
- Third-party games often show low-resolution art or a generic engine logo; a community SteamGridDB widget exists to replace it.

Tile metadata

- PC: store-origin icon; handheld badges (Handheld Optimized, Mostly Compatible); subscription badge (August 2026); install state; duplicates across stores appear side by side.
- Console: install-status and subscription badges; since July 2026 users choose which badges appear on tiles and in recents.
- Hover behaviour on PC tiles is unconfirmed.

Collections, pinning, hiding, manual add

- Console groups: named, user-ordered collections that sync to the account; shown in My games & apps, Home and the Guide; up to 10 pinned to Home since April 2026.
- PC: no user collections; a collapsible Play Later list; right-click > Pin to this list for up to 3 games.
- Hiding: the PC library cannot hide individual games (Windows Central, November 2025); the console has long hidden Ready to Install content.
- Manual add (PC): + opens "Add Games To Library"; pick from a list or browse for an .exe or .cmd, then edit name, path, artwork and command-line options; removing an entry does not uninstall.

Game detail page and actions

Both PC and console use a "Game Hub" page per game with Play as the first focus, followed by sections for add-ons, achievements, playtime and captures; management sits behind a separate Manage view.

PC Game Hub (Insiders February 2024, all users April 2024)

- Top bar with launch, install or update, View Details (reviews, purchase, wishlist), and a notice if the game is leaving Game Pass.

- Sections: add-ons, friends who play, achievements with Show All, developer news, stats including HowLongToBeat estimates, local captures.
- Right-click or long-press a tile > Manage: General (uninstall), Add-ons, and custom launch parameters (June 2026).
- Garrison merges store and game pages into one; hero-art treatment on PC hubs is unconfirmed.

Console Game Hub (March 2025)

- Playtime, Gamerscore, recent achievements, captures, DLC, events, friends playing, and a save-sync indicator (2026).
- Default focus is always on Play, so a second A press launches; X on a recents tile skips the hub; hubs can be turned off.
- More options > Manage Quick Resume, or per-game Quick Resume settings (April 2026).

Gamepad and fullscreen behaviour

Xbox's controller model is A select, B back, Y search, with focus memory between pages and optional navigation sounds; Xbox mode adds a system-level task switcher that a GNOME app cannot replicate.

- **PC app** (August 2025): A selects, B goes back, Y opens search; Microsoft cited smoother trigger and bumper behaviour, faster scrolling, focus memory between pages and clearer focus indicators. Navigation sounds for move, select and back arrived in February 2026 and can be turned off.
- **Xbox mode**: the Xbox button opens Game Bar (with Home and Library); a long press opens the task switcher (LB/RB or stick to move, A to switch, X to close); Win+F11 toggles the mode; one window shows at a time, full screen. Known issues include windows losing controller focus.
- **Console**: the Menu button opens a tile's context menu (pin, game hub, manage, uninstall); View jumps to Manage. These mappings come from 2016 documentation; current behaviour is unconfirmed.
- Bumper or trigger tab switching inside the library is unconfirmed on all surfaces.

Overlap with Adwaita and the widgets that reproduce it

The resemblance is structural (sidebar plus content, flat surfaces, rounded cards, pill call to action), so almost every Xbox library element has a stock libadwaita or GTK counterpart; what does not translate is Mica translucency and the icon-only compact rail.

Fluent traits behind the Xbox look (rounded corners, Mica, typography, NavigationView)

- Corners of 4 px on controls and 8 px on windows, flyouts and dialogs.
- Mica: an opaque, wallpaper-tinted base layer under the title bar, with content on cards.
- Segoe UI Variable type ramp: body 14/20, subtitle 20/28, title 28/36.
- NavigationView switches between full, compact and minimal at 1008 px and 641 px, with a 52 px header and 24 px content margins.

Mapping

Xbox element	libadwaita / GTK equivalent	Fit
Left sidebar with library, recents, groups	`AdwNavigationSplitView` (or `AdwOverlaySplitView`) with a `navigation-sidebar` list	Direct; sidebar defaults to 25% width within 180–280 sp
Compact icon-only sidebar	`AdwBreakpoint` collapsing the sidebar entirely	Partial: Adwaita has no icon rail
My games / My apps / Play history tabs	`AdwViewStack` with `AdwViewSwitcher` in the header bar	Direct
Stackable filters (Owned + Installable)	Row of toggle buttons in a wrap box, or a filter popover with check items	Direct; exclusive toggle groups do not fit multi-select
Sort control	`GtkMenuButton` with radio actions in the header bar	Direct
Search (Y button)	`GtkSearchBar` with `GtkSearchEntry` and type-to-search	Direct
Art tile grid	`GtkGridView` over filter and sort list models, `.card` tiles	Direct

Xbox element	libadwaita / GTK equivalent	Fit
Store and install badges	`GtkOverlay` with small `.osd` pills on the tile, kept out of the bottom third	Direct
Recents and play-history rows	Horizontal `GtkListView` above the grid	Direct
Game Hub with Play first	`AdwNavigationPage` pushed on an `AdwNavigationView`: hero `GtkPicture`, `.pill.suggested-action` Play, preference groups below	Direct
Manage view and manual add	`AdwDialog` or `AdwPreferencesDialog` with entry, combo and switch rows	Direct
Notifications	`AdwToastOverlay`	Direct
Mica and wallpaper tint	None; at most a blurred hero image behind the detail page (as Cartridges does)	Not available

Differences to accept

- Adwaita windows use a larger radius (15 px window radius) and no translucent materials.
- Adwaita header bars put the view switcher or title in the centre, primary actions at the start and menus at the end, and avoid text-only or suggested buttons there; Xbox uses a 52 px page header next to a separate rail.
- Accent colour is the user's choice from Adwaita's presets, never a brand green.
- Xbox is controller-first with focus memory and sounds; GNOME apps are keyboard and pointer first, so the controller layer is ours to add.

Adopt, adapt, avoid

Take Xbox's information architecture and tile rules; express them with Adwaita widgets and keep every trace of Microsoft branding out.

Adopt

- A split view with sidebar sections: Library (All, Installed), one entry per launcher, Play history, Collections, plus a Recent list with up to three pinned games.
- Multi-select filters that combine (Installed, Owned, Launcher), as Xbox mode does.
- A launcher badge and install-state badges on tiles, with a preference to hide badges (console, July 2026).
- 2:3 poster art as the main tile, square as fallback, 16:9 hero art for the detail header; keep text and badges out of the bottom third or add a gradient.
- A detail page whose default focus is a pill Play button, then sections for add-ons, achievements, playtime and captures, and a Manage dialog with launch options.
- Manual + add with editable name, path, art and arguments; per-launcher hide in Preferences.

Adapt

- Console sort options (A–Z, last played, size, last updated) become a sort menu in the header bar.
- A tile-size or tile-style preference instead of a grid/list switch.
- Console groups become user Collections in the sidebar.
- Gamepad: A activate, B back, Y search, LB/RB switch views, Menu opens the context menu, View opens Manage (the last two inferred from console conventions).
- A fullscreen mode with larger scale and focus memory between pages.

Avoid

- Mica-style translucency.
- Separate store and library pages (Microsoft is merging them in Garrison).
- Marketing rows on the library page.
- Dropdowns that are hard to drive with a controller.
- Microsoft brand assets: no Xbox name in the app name or UI, no logos or glyph art, no Xbox green as identity colour. The Microsoft trademark guidelines cover logos, designs and trade dress and forbid implying affiliation; describe the app as inspired by console launchers. This is not legal advice.

Open questions

- Exact PC tile ratio, size and hover states; whether the PC app has a grid/list toggle.
- Full current PC sort list, and whether an in-library launcher filter exists.
- Whether Xbox mode's library has its own layout or is the PC app scaled up.

- Garrison's final layout and release date.

Sources

Xbox Wire and Microsoft

- Aggregated gaming library coming to the Xbox PC app (2025-06-23)
- Access your gaming library, apps and play history on PC and handheld (2025-09-15)
- My Apps for Xbox Insiders (2025-08-21), August 2025 update: play history, controller updates, Cross-device play history and cloud playable games
- ROG Xbox Ally features, essential tips, full screen experience for Insiders
- Xbox mode rolls out to Windows 11 PCs, April 2026 update, June 2026 console features, January 2026 update
- Release notes: Xbox app 2402.1001.20.0 (Game Hubs), 2309.1001.3.0, 2307, March 2023 PC updates, Groups (2018)
- Full screen experience KB5070297, Windows Experience Blog: Xbox mode, Handheld compatibility
- Microsoft Learn: consolidate PC games in one library, store screenshots and images, rounded corners, geometry, Mica, typography, NavigationView
- Microsoft Trademark and Brand Guidelines

Press and community

- Windows Central: new PC app hands-on (2026-10-09), Xbox mode is here, library shows Steam and GOG games, Xbox Ally re-reviewed, SteamGridDB widget, Game Hubs testing, revamped Games & Apps (2022), Play History tab
- Pure Xbox: Steam integration, manual add on PC, poster tiles and July 2026 features, PC app refresh first look, Game Hubs on console, Xbox mode arrived
- ElevenForum: console update 10.0.26100.8866, Xbox app 2604.1001.9.0, 2606.1001.27.0
- Windows Latest: Xbox mode tested, PCWorld: Xbox app pulls in Steam games, GeneracionXbox: unified library, Neowin: improved filters, Digital Citizen: July 2026 update, Wikipedia: Xbox (app)

GNOME references used for the mapping

- libadwaita NavigationSplitView, style classes, CSS variables, GNOME HIG: header bars